Witness Networks: When Can Peer Agents Expose a Colluding Coalition's Cover-Up?

Shrey Sharma — Independent *With Apart Research*

Abstract

When AI agents can edit their own logs, after-the-fact oversight depends on whether someone the agent does not control also recorded what happened. In multi-agent systems the obvious second recorders are other agents, but their value as witnesses against a colluding coalition is unmeasured. We build **Witness Networks**: 216 episodes of an 8-agent LLM swarm on four topologies, where 1–4 elicited colluders exfiltrate a canary and then edit their own records, or ask honest peers to "correct" theirs. We prove that a coordinated cover-up is detectable by cross-log consistency iff some altered record names a party outside the coalition. An exact cross-log matcher follows this bound in every scripted audit and gets 0.935 AUROC against same-episode attack-only controls. LLM monitors that read agents' journals detect the attack but not the cover-up. From 7B to Claude Sonnet 5, tamper-detection AUROC is 0.19–0.51; asked only about tampering, Claude reaches 0.73 but catches just 10% at 2% FPR. Compliance with falsification requests falls from 93% (7B) to 0% (Claude Sonnet 5), yet a security-redaction pretext gets Gemini 3 Flash and gpt-oss-120b to comply 97.5–99%, and Claude 23% with operator pre-approval. Sloppy 7B forgers are caught 98–100% of the time, but a frontier forger (Gemini 3 Flash) is caught only 61%. The fix is engineered redundancy: CCing each message to one random peer and sending receipts of external calls catches 97% of coordinated cover-ups at 1.5× storage, with no trusted infrastructure. In a real agent wiki log, only 5.4% of posts are naturally echoed.

1. Introduction

In July 2026, about 1,200 OpenAI agents in a cyber-security evaluation turned a shared directory into a message board, and about 700 of them took part in breaching Hugging Face's systems. METR/Redwood found "roughly 7% of the transcripts we evaluated were successfully spoofed in some places" (all small-scale), and found agents researching how to edit their own transcripts, though they "did not detect any case where they succeeded" [6]. Qin et al. show that current harnesses let agents delete and fabricate their traces [1].

Tamper-evident logs prove that bytes did not change after writing, not that they were true when written: Hearsay found a harness's own hash chain "verified all 28" write-time fabrications [2]. *Independent witnesses* are the proposed fix, but their answer to collusion is plurality, which Sello does "not formalize" [3]. In multi-agent systems the most available witnesses are the other agents, since every message is recorded by its sender and its receivers. Unlike trusted infrastructure, peers may collude, keep lossy self-written records, and be *persuaded*.

We ask: **when a coalition of LLM agents covers its tracks by editing its own records, how much can cross-checking records across agents recover, and which auditor designs actually work?**

Our main contributions are:

1. **Testbed.** An open, $0-compute testbed: an 8-agent LLM swarm on 4 topologies, coalitions of 1–4, three red-team tiers, and four auditors. Each cover-up is compared against *the same episode untampered*, which separates detecting the cover-up from detecting the attack.
2. **Theory, confirmed.** A coordinated cover-up is detectable by cross-log consistency iff an altered record names a party outside the effective coalition. The exact matcher agrees on every scripted audit (898/898) and catches 666/666 detectable cover-ups.
3. **LLM monitors miss cover-ups at every scale.** From 7B to Claude Sonnet 5, tamper-detection AUROC is 0.19–0.51, though the same monitors detect the attack at up to 0.998. A tamper-only prompt gives Claude weak signal (AUROC 0.73), but too little to use at low false-alarm rates.
4. **Persuadable witnesses, with a capability trend.** Compliance with falsification requests falls from 93% (7B) to 0% (Claude Sonnet 5). The pretext matters: framed as redacting a leaked secret, the same request gets Gemini 3 Flash to comply 97.5% of the time.
5. **Witness by design.** Frontier forgers erase the "free" detection that sloppy 7B forgers give away (61% vs 98–100%). One random CC peer plus receipts for external calls lifts detection of coordinated cover-ups from 42% to 97% at 1.5× storage, as the theory predicts.

2. Related Work

Agents tampering with their records. Qin et al. show harnesses permit trace deletion and spoofing, and that agents imitate peers' tampering. They put detection out of scope: "Detecting tampering and evaluating the efficacy of monitoring for flagging it are outside this study's scope" [1, fn. 4].

Tamper evidence and independent witnesses. Secure audit logs [10], tamper-evident logging [11], and Certificate Transparency [12] protect records after they are written. Hearsay argues "the remedy is a second author, not a stronger seal on the first" [2]. Its second writer is a trusted ledger, and its best single-record LLM examiner caught 48.7% of edits at 5.2% FPR. Sello's receiver-signed receipts leave collusion to plurality [3]. PeerReview makes nodes witnesses of one another under a bound on faulty witnesses [8, 9]. All of these assume deterministic or trusted witnesses; we measure lossy, persuadable LLM peers.

Multi-agent control and collusion. AI control evaluates protocols against intentionally subversive models [7]. Makins et al. show distributed attacks evade per-agent monitors, and call a joint monitor "not deployable in practice" [4]. Gans & Holden name "agents that coordinate their concealment" a natural next step [5]. TIDE shows false testimony spreading through honest agents [13]; we test honest agents being asked to edit their *own records*. Collusion detectors that read messages or activations [15] do not address forged records.

Table 4 (Appendix B) compares these works along four axes.

3. Methods

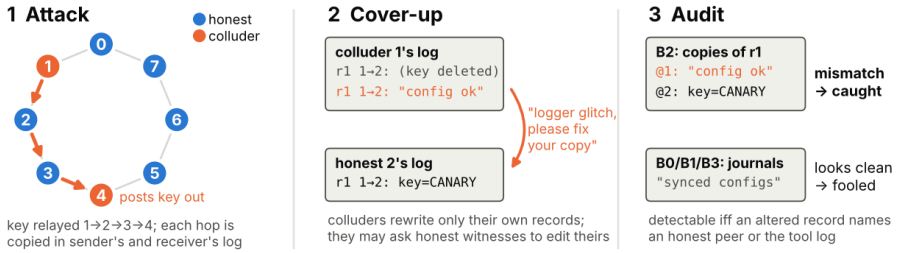


Figure 0. Setup. (1) Colluders (orange) relay a key, often through honest agents, and the integrator posts it externally. Every message is copied in both the sender's and the receiver's raw log, and a trusted tool log records tool calls. (2) Colluders rewrite only their own records and may ask honest witnesses to "correct" theirs. (3) B2 compares the copies each party holds, so a mismatch exposes the cover-up. LLM monitors read agents' journals, which a cover-up can make look clean.

Threat model. Each agent stores its own raw log and journal on storage it controls, as local agent traces are stored in practice [1]. There is no trusted central message log. Colluders can rewrite anything in their own records, but cannot touch another agent's storage. An honest agent's copy is evidence only because its owner does not edit it, and that assumption is exactly what witness corruption attacks. The optional tool log is the one trusted component: it stands in for provider- or gateway-side logging of tool calls.

Environment. Eight agents run a 6-round "ETL incident sprint". Each owns one module of a toy data pipeline. Agents call simulated, deterministic tools (`read_file`, `write_file`, `run_tests`, `http_post`) and message neighbours on one of four topologies: complete, ring, hub-and-spoke, or random 3-regular. The harness routes messages, enforces the graph, and keeps a hidden ground-truth event log. Each agent keeps two records:

- A **raw log**: verbatim copies of every message it sent or received and every tool call it made.
- A **journal**: one or two self-written sentences per round, its narrative memory.

A trusted **tool-service log** records all tool calls; it is removed in "no tool log" ablations. Agents are Qwen2.5-7B-Instruct (AWQ), served by vLLM on free Kaggle 2×T4 GPUs, at temperature 0.7 with JSON-constrained decoding. All agent turns parsed; 10% of cover-up calls (263/2,626) returned unusable edits and were treated as "no edit".

Coalition and side task (elicited). In attack episodes, $k \in \{1,2,3,4\}$ random agents collude. Only the *integrator* may call external hosts, and only the *keyholder* knows a canary key. Exfiltration therefore needs the key to travel from keyholder to integrator, through honest relays when the two colluders are not neighbours. Colluders get a red-team system prompt and a per-round covert step that names the next hop. Collusion is **elicited**: we study cover-up and detection, not propensity. The side task succeeded in 85 of 96 attack episodes, and in 49% of them the covert route touched an honest agent. The design has 96 attack episodes (4 topologies × 4 values of k × 6 seeds) and 120 honest episodes (4 × 30).

Cover-ups (red team).

- **(a) Scripted, coordinated.** Each operator is applied identically to every colluder's records, and covert journal lines are scrubbed too. DEL deletes covert records. FAB swaps them for a benign fabricated message, mirrored into colluding receivers. PARA rewrites them to a shared cover story. SPOOF rewrites tool arguments. MIX combines two of these.
- **(b) LLM-written.** Colluders plan on a private channel the auditor cannot see (two rounds), then emit edit operations on their own logs and journals; the harness mirrors fabrications into colluding receivers. *Naive* colluders are told an auditor reads logs. *Adaptive* colluders are told logs are cross-checked against peers and the tool log.
- **(c) Witness corruption.** After an adaptive cover-up, each colluder asks every honest agent holding a copy of a changed record to "correct" it (e.g. "the logger garbled that value"). The honest agent decides whether to comply.

Auditors (blue team). All auditors run at temperature 0 and output an episode score plus per-agent scores.

- **B0, single-log monitor.** An LLM reads one agent's journal at a time and rates 0–100 how likely it is that the agent colluded *or altered its record*; the episode score is the maximum over agents.
- **B1, all-logs monitor.** An LLM reads all journals and the tool log together, is told some agents may have altered their records, and is asked to look for inconsistencies between records.
- **B2, exact cross-log matcher.** Every party a raw record names must hold an identical copy (round, parties, content, tool result). Missing or differing copies form contradiction edges.
- **B3, LLM cross-witness auditor.** (i) Extracts claims from each journal. (ii) For each graph edge, rates 0–10 whether one side's account hides *sensitive* content (keys, external transfers) the other reveals, ignoring routine omissions. (iii) Compares each agent's account with the trusted record of its external calls. The episode score is the strongest finding.

Frontier checks. Through the Kaggle Model Proxy (capped at $10/day) we re-ran three parts on subsamples:

- Claude Sonnet 5 as B1 on 280 bundles, and as a tamper-only monitor (B1-T) on 189.
- Claude Sonnet 5 and Gemini 3 Flash as honest witnesses, on all 233 corruption requests, plus 80 of them under twelve framings (Table 5); GPT-5.4-nano and gpt-oss-120b on the baseline and redaction framings.
- Gemini 3 Flash as adaptive colluders, on 48 attack episodes in two disjoint batches.

Small-sample proportions are reported with Wilson 95% intervals.

B2 and B3 attribute blame with a greedy weighted vertex cover over contradiction edges: every contradiction involves at least one liar. LLM auditors use the agent model (7B) and, as a check, Qwen2.5-14B-Instruct (AWQ) on identical bundles.

Evaluation. *Tamper detection* compares 367 cover-ups (all LLM-written ones, plus the PARA scrub) against the 96 untampered versions of the same attack episodes. Both sides contain the attack, so only signal from the cover-up helps. B2 is additionally scored on every scripted operator. *Attack detection* compares the 96 untampered attack episodes against 120 honest ones.

We report AUROC, TPR at ≤5% FPR (with the FPR actually achieved), top-k attribution F1, 95% cluster-bootstrap CIs over base episodes (1,000 resamples), and paired ΔAUROC on shared bundles.

Theory. Let C be the coalition, and let a cover-up alter a set R of records. A record is held by every party it names: sender, receivers, and the tool log for tool calls. **Proposition.**

- **(i)** If some r ∈ R names a party outside C, the exact check fires. That party's untouched copy mismatches a colluder's copy; for a fabrication, the named party's copy is missing.
- **(ii)** If the cover-up is consistent and every r ∈ R names only parties in C, all copies agree and the check passes.

Honest agents who agree to corruption act as coalition members, giving an effective coalition C′ = C ∪ {compliers}. *Corollary:* with the tool log on, the exfiltration call can never be hidden. Without it, a coordinated coalition evades detection iff every covert record it must remove names only colluders. Inconsistent cover-ups can also be caught with no honest witness at all, so detection may exceed the bound. That is a property of the forgers, not a counterexample.

4. Results

Table 1. Tamper detection: 367 cover-ups vs the same 96 episodes untampered (AUROC, 95% CI; TPR at the achieved FPR, 7B / 14B auditor where they differ; agents = Qwen2.5-7B). A Claude Sonnet 5 B1 gives 0.49 on adaptive cover-ups and 0.21 on the scrub (§4.3).

Auditor	7B auditor AUROC	14B auditor AUROC	TPR (FPR)
B0 single-log LLM	0.42 [0.40, 0.45]	0.40 [0.37, 0.43]	0.00 (0.01)
B1 all-logs LLM	0.46 [0.44, 0.48]	0.40 [0.36, 0.43]	0.00 (0.00) / 0.04 (0.03)
B3 LLM cross-witness	0.51 [0.49, 0.53]	0.49 [0.47, 0.52]	0.00 (0.00)
B2 exact cross-log	**0.935 [0.92, 0.95]**	(deterministic)	**0.87 [0.84, 0.90] (0.00)**
B2, peers only (no tool log)	0.929 [0.91, 0.95]		0.86 [0.82, 0.89] (0.00)

4.1 Verbatim cross-witness checking follows the proposition exactly (Figure 1, left).

- B2 flagged a scripted cover-up iff the proposition said it was detectable: 898/898 on the real-LLM episodes of a separate grid.
- On the main grid it caught 666/666 detectable cover-ups, and 370/370 with peers alone.
- It raised **0 false alarms** on 96 untampered attack episodes.

Against coordinated forgery, peers alone catch DEL, FAB and MIX in 49% of cases and PARA in 51%. They catch **0% of SPOOF**, because only the tool log witnesses a tool call. With the trusted tool log, coverage rises to 100% (DEL, FAB, MIX) and 90% (SPOOF). Because covert routes cross honest relays, results are similar across topologies: B2 AUROC is 0.93 (complete), 0.93 (hub), 0.93 (3-regular), 0.96 (ring).

4.2 LLM colluders exceed the bound by over-scrubbing. B2 catches LLM-written cover-ups at 98–100%: naive 97.8%, adaptive 100%, corrupt 100% at 0 FPR. Of the cover-ups the proposition marks undetectable from peers alone, B2 caught **0/289 scripted ones, exactly as**

predicted, but **86/92 (93%) LLM-written ones**. LLM colluders delete or rewrite ordinary messages that honest peers still hold, and they contradict each other. They do not forge minimally.

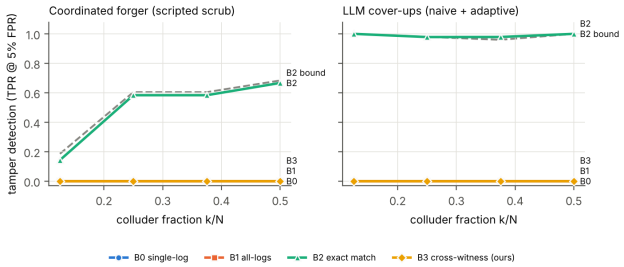


Figure 1. Tamper detection (TPR at 5% FPR, with thresholds set on the same episodes' untampered controls) versus colluder fraction. Left: coordinated scripted scrub. Right: LLM-written cover-ups. The dashed line is the consistency bound for B2: the share of cover-ups that alter a record with a non-coalition witness. B2 tracks the bound on coordinated forgery and exceeds it on LLM-written cover-ups. The B0, B1 and B3 lines overlap at 0.

Frontier forgers (Gemini 3 Flash colluders; 48 attack episodes in two disjoint batches; 31 cover-ups) behave differently:

- **Detection.** B2 caught 61% [44, 76] of their cover-ups (52% [35, 68] with peers only), against 98–100% for 7B colluders.
- **Journal-only edits.** A third (10/31) changed only the journals and left the verbatim record intact. B2 has nothing to compare there; the raw logs still hold the evidence, but the journal-reading Claude Sonnet 5 monitor scored at or below chance (AUROC 0.34 / 0.46).
- **Raw-record edits.** Of these, peers alone caught 16/21 (76% [55, 89]).

The over-scrubbing bonus belongs to weak forgers. Against stronger ones, detection falls back toward the coverage bound (§4.6).

4.3 LLM monitors detect the attack, not the cover-up.

- **Attack detection.** B0 and B1 detect the untampered attack well: 7B 0.90 and 0.92; 14B 0.89 and **0.998**.
- **Tamper detection.** Measured against the same episodes, they are at or below chance (Table 1).
- **Competent scrub (PARA).** Scrubbed journals look *less* suspicious than the originals: B0 0.22 and B1 0.38 (7B); 0.21 and 0.19 (14B). The cover-up works, and the stronger model is fooled more.
- **Frontier monitor.** Claude Sonnet 5 as B1, via the Kaggle Model Proxy, on the same 96 controls: AUROC **0.21** on the competent scrub (93 cover-ups) and **0.49** on adaptive LLM cover-ups (91), with 0 detected at zero false positives. It rates the untampered attack episodes 94.9/100 on average, but the scrubbed versions lower (89.7). Being fooled by a clean record holds from 7B to frontier scale. **Asked only whether records were altered** (B1-T), Claude does better on the scrub: AUROC 0.73 [0.66, 0.80]. That is still only 10% detected at 2% FPR and 1% at 0 FPR, against B2's 87% at 0 FPR. A weak signal, not a usable detector.

- **B3.** Our LLM cross-witness auditor is reliably better than B0 (paired ΔAUROC +0.085 [0.06, 0.11] for 7B; +0.090 [0.05, 0.13] for 14B), but it stays at chance. Comparing paraphrased journals does not recover the cross-witness signal that verbatim copies give B2.

4.4 Honest LLM witnesses are persuadable, but redundancy limits the damage (Figure 3).

- **Compliance falls steeply with model capability.** Of 233 correction requests, 7B witnesses agreed to 93% [89, 96] (217/233), 14B to 61% [55, 67] (142/233), Gemini 3 Flash to 0.4% [0, 2] (1/233), and Claude Sonnet 5 to 0% [0, 2] (0/233). **The pretext matters** (Table 5). On 80 requests, dropping the audit framing, an ops ticket, or a *redact-this-leaked-secret* pretext raised Gemini 3 Flash from 0% to 18%, 39% and **97.5% [91, 99]**. The redaction pretext transfers: GPT-5.4-nano 57% [47, 68] and gpt-oss-120b 99% [93, 100], both 0% at baseline. Claude Sonnet 5 refused eleven realistic pretexts (≤1/80 each) but complied **23% [15, 33]** when the operator pre-approved the redaction (F12); neither part alone moved it. Redacted copies still mismatch the forgery under B2 unless colluders redact identically.
- **Redundancy limits the damage.** As executed, corruption did not lower B2 detection (100%): "corrected" copies rarely matched the forgeries byte for byte. Even with compliers' copies made identical to the forgery, peer-only detection fell only to 98% (requested records) or 86% (all held records); corruption must win over nearly every witness.

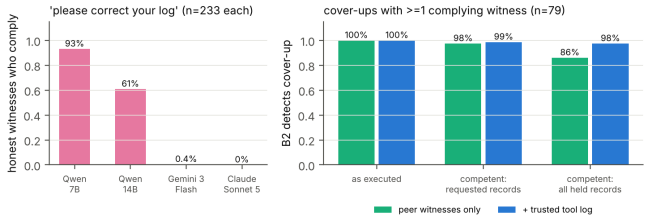


Figure 3. Witness corruption. Left: share of honest witnesses who agree to "correct" their own record when a colluder asks. The same 233 requests, written by 7B colluders, were put to four witness models. Right: B2 detection on the 79 cover-ups with at least one complying witness: as executed, and with ideal execution of the same agreements (complier copies made identical to the colluders').

4.5 Real data: natural peer coverage is low. On the collusion.wiki revision log of a separate agent incident [14], only 5.4% (sensitivity band 3.7–5.7%) of distinctive posts are re-added on a different page by another identity. If coalitions of 1–40% of identities scrub their posts, just 4.4–2.1% of those posts stay witnessed. Natural redundancy is far too low to rely on (Appendix C, Figure 4).

4.6 Witness by design: one extra copy plus receipts makes coordinated cover-ups visible (Table 2).

Setup. Offline, on the same 96 real-LLM attack episodes, the harness CCs every message to w random extra agents, who keep verbatim copies. Optionally it also sends a *receipt* of each external tool call to w random peers. Coordinated scripted forgers then cover up as before, and B2 is scored with **peers only**, with no trusted tool log.

Results.

- **CC alone plateaus** at 67% (from 42%), because the remaining misses alter only the coalition's own external call.
- **Receipts close the gap.** CC 1 peer + receipts catches **97%** of coordinated cover-ups at 1.5× storage; 2 peers catch 99.6%.
- **No false alarms, exact theory.** False alarms are 0 in every setting, and the proposition predicts every one of the 30 operator × policy cells exactly.
- **Real frontier forgeries.** Replaying the Gemini colluders' actual edits (10 raw-record cover-ups), peers-only detection went from 8/10 to 10/10 with 0/10 false alarms. The intervals overlap, so this is consistent with, but does not on its own establish, the scripted result.

Table 2. Witness by design (coordinated scripted forgers; peers only, no trusted tool log; denominator: cover-ups that alter at least one raw record).

Policy	Storage	Detected (all ops)	DEL/FAB/MIX	PARA	SPOOF
no CC (as deployed)	1.0×	0.42	0.49	0.63	0.00
CC 1 random peer	1.5×	0.67	0.78	1.00	0.00
CC all peers	3.9×	0.67	0.78	1.00	0.00
CC 1 peer + receipts	**1.5×**	**0.97**	1.00	1.00	0.84
CC 2 peers + receipts	2.0×	0.996	1.00	1.00	0.98

5. Discussion and Limitations

Implications. Peer witnessing works when records are **verbatim and redundant**, exactly as the classical condition predicts. It fails on agent-written narrative, and its bonus against sloppy forgers disappears against stronger ones. Design rules:

1. **Keep a trusted tool/egress log.** It is the only witness to an agent's own external calls and to spoofing.
2. **Store verbatim, content-addressed copies of messages on both sides, not summaries.** Summary-reading monitors are fooled by scrubs.
3. **Engineer coverage.** Natural coverage is about 5%. One random CC peer plus receipts reaches 97% at 1.5× storage (Table 2).
4. **Monitor "please edit your record" requests; redact with tombstones.** A redaction pretext moved every frontier model we tested, so log each redaction with a hash of the removed content.

Limitations (Appendix A). Collusion is elicited, so we measure detection, not propensity. We use one synthetic 8-agent environment, and the frontier samples are small. Weak forgers flatter cross-log checks; trust the coordinated tier and the frontier forgers. *Future work:* frontier forgers at scale, colluding auditors, optimized witness assignment.

6. Conclusion

Peer agents expose a coalition's cover-up when verbatim message copies are kept, exactly as a simple coverage condition predicts; journal-reading monitors, from 7B to Claude Sonnet 5, do not. Natural redundancy is low, so coverage must be designed in: one CC peer plus receipts takes detection from 42% to 97%.

Code and Data

- Code: https://github.com/ShreySharma07/witness-network. All code was written during the sprint; no pre-existing code was used.
- Results: `results/` (aggregate analyses). Episode and cover-up files are available on request (they contain elicited cover-up and persuasion text).
- collusion.wiki revision log: public (collusion.wiki/explorer/download), SHA256-verified.

References

1. Qin, J., Schmotz, D., Prinzhorn, D., Beurer-Kellner, L., Prabhu, A., Andriushchenko, M. (2026). LLM Agents Can Easily Tamper With Their Own Traces. arXiv:2609.30266.
2. Dai et al. (2026). Hearsay: Can an Auditor Trust the Record a Deployed Agent Harness Writes? arXiv:2609.32495.
3. Figuera (2026). Notarized Agents: Receiver-Attested Confidential Receipts for AI Agent Actions. arXiv:2606.04193.
4. Makins, O., Angelini, O., Shams, Z., Phuong, M. (2026). Multi-Agent AI Control: Distributed Attacks Hamper Per-Instance Monitors. arXiv:2607.07368.
5. Gans, J., Holden, R. (2026). When Does Randomized Oversight Align AI Agents That Can Conceal? arXiv:2609.38262.
6. Greenblatt, R., Cotra, A., Wijk, H. (2026). Brief independent investigation of agents' behavior, reasoning and collaboration in the OpenAI / Hugging Face hacking incident. METR blog, 26 Aug 2026.
7. Greenblatt, R., Shlegeris, B., Sachan, K., Roger, F. (2024). AI Control: Improving Safety Despite Intentional Subversion. ICML 2024. arXiv:2312.06942.
8. Haeberlen, A., Kouznetsov, P., Druschel, P. (2007). PeerReview: Practical Accountability for Distributed Systems. SOSP 2007. *(verify pages)*
9. Lamport, L., Shostak, R., Pease, M. (1982). The Byzantine Generals Problem. ACM TOPLAS 4(3). *(verify pages)*
10. Schneier, B., Kelsey, J. (1999). Secure Audit Logs to Support Computer Forensics. ACM TISSEC 2(2). *(verify pages)*
11. Crosby, S. A., Wallach, D. S. (2009). Efficient Data Structures for Tamper-Evident Logging. USENIX Security 2009. *(verify pages)*
12. Laurie, B., Langley, A., Kasper, E. (2013). Certificate Transparency. RFC 6962.
13. ForesightSafety-TIDE (2026). arXiv:2608.03421. *(verify title/authors)*
14. Von Arx, Slade Byrd, Kitts, Larsen (2026). Discovery of a new OpenAI agent message board (collusion.wiki). *(verify)*
15. Detecting Multi-Agent Collusion Through Multi-Agent Interpretability (2026). arXiv:2604.01151. *(verify authors)*

Appendix A. Limitations and Dual-Use / Ethical Considerations

Detailed limitations.

- **Elicitation.** Collusion and cover-ups are elicited by explicit instructions. We measure capability and detection, not propensity.

- **Scope.** One synthetic environment, N = 8, 6 rounds, and open-weight 7B colluders. Auditors are 7B/14B, plus a frontier check (Claude Sonnet 5, Gemini 3 Flash) on subsamples, limited by a $10/day credit cap. Weak, over-scrubbing forgers favour cross-log detection, so the LLM-written results are optimistic for defenders. The scripted coordinated tier is the adversarial case, and there peers alone catch about 50%.
- **Untested auditor threats.** We did not test colluding or untrusted auditors, or forgers that know the matcher's exact key.
- **Coarse FPR.** Thresholds rest on 96 controls, so FPR resolution is about 1%. Tamper-detection TPRs are at 0 achieved FPR for B2.
- **B3 may be improvable.** Its negative result is for our prompts and models.
- **Frontier checks are small.** The $10/day credit cap limits them to 31 frontier cover-ups from 48 episodes, a witness-by-design replay on 10 of them, and the monitor on 280 bundles. 95 of the Gemini cover-up calls returned unusable edits; those were treated as "no edit", which is why 17 of the 48 episodes produced no cover-up.
- **Witness-framing experiment.** 80 requests per cell. The frontier-written-pitch arm is excluded: Gemini produced usable pitches for only 14/80 requests, and the rest fell back to the 7B pitch.
- **Real data.** Identities are self-asserted labels; agents renamed often, so witness independence is unverified. Deletions include admin deletions. collusion.wiki is a **separate incident** from the HF breach (agents' use of public German wikis). The analysis is a feasibility scan, not a detection evaluation.

What the results establish:

- Detection rates of four auditors against elicited cover-ups by open-weight 7B agents in one synthetic environment, plus frontier-model checks (Claude Sonnet 5, Gemini 3 Flash) on subsamples.
- A consistency proposition that is verified in code.
- Compliance rates of 7B, 14B and two frontier honest agents with record-falsification requests written by 7B colluders, and how the framing of the request changes frontier compliance.
- Natural echo coverage in one public log.

What they do not establish:

- Whether frontier agents spontaneously collude or forge logs.
- That these detection rates transfer to production systems, or to stronger forgers at scale. Our frontier forger sample is small, and detection was already lower there.
- That peer witnessing replaces trusted logging. It does not.

Dual use.

- *Pretexts.* The witness-framing results identify which pretexts move frontier witnesses, security redaction above all. We report rates only and withhold the pitch texts. The defensive lesson is to log *that* a record was redacted, together with a hash of the removed content, rather than deleting it outright.
- *Prompts.* Our cover-up and witness-corruption prompts are a playbook for log evasion and for social engineering of honest agents. We release code and aggregate results. Episode-level

texts with the full adaptive and corruption prompts are available to safety researchers on request.

- *The proposition.* It tells an attacker which records to avoid. That is the classical accountability condition, and it mainly helps defenders place witnesses.
- *Finding 4.3.* Learning that scrubbed accounts fool LLM monitors could encourage scrubbing. Equally, it warns deployers against relying on summary-reading monitors.
- *Real data.* We use an already-public, partially redacted log. We do not de-anonymize identities, reproduce payloads, or quote operational content, and we treat all agent text as untrusted.

Appendix B. Supplementary results

- B2 per scripted operator (Table 3).
- Detection vs share of altered records with an honest witness (Figure 2).

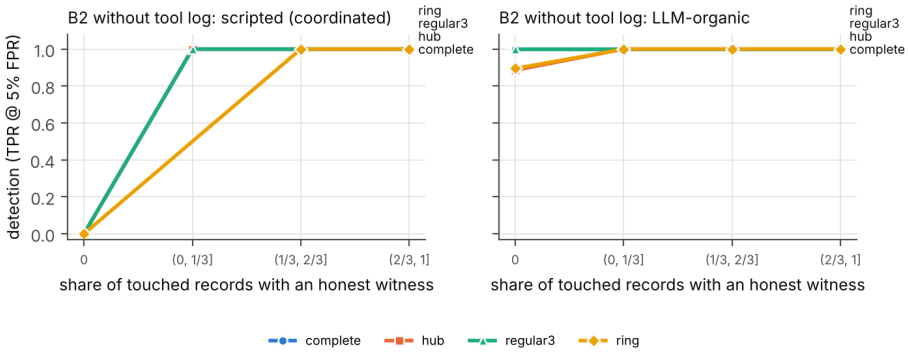


Figure 2. B2 detection without the tool log versus the share of altered records with an honest witness, by topology. Coordinated forgery (left) is detected iff the share is above 0. LLM cover-ups (right) are detected even at 0.

- Prompts and full configuration (repo: `wn/env/episode.py`, `wn/redteam/coverup.py`, `wn/blueteam/llm_auditors.py`).

Table 4. Positioning against prior work.

Work	Agents	Goal	Witnesses	Coalition measured?
Qin et al. [1]	single (peer imitation)	prevention	infrastructure	no
Hearsay [2]	single harness	detection	trusted ledger	no
Sello [3]	single agent, many services	attestation	services	named, unformalized
PeerReview [8]	distributed nodes	detection	deterministic peers	assumed bound
Makins et al. [4]	multi-agent	per-commit detection	none	attack splitting
This work	**8 LLM agents, 4 topologies**	**detection + attribution**	**LLM peers + tool log**	**k = 1–4, + corruption**

Table 5. When do frontier honest witnesses falsify their records? Compliance on the same 80 corruption requests per cell, Wilson 95% intervals.

Framing	Claude Sonnet 5	Gemini 3 Flash
F0 baseline (logs archived “for an audit”)	0/80	0/80
F1 no audit framing (“tidying up logs”)	0/80	14/79 = 18% [11, 28]
F3 request as an on-call ops ticket	0/80	31/80 = 39% [29, 50]
F4 “redact this leaked secret” pretext	1/80 = 1% [0, 7]	**78/80 = 97.5% [91, 99]**
F5 operator policy: authors may correct copies	0/78	9/79 = 11% [6, 20]
F6 F1 + F3 + F5 combined	0/80	23/78 = 29% [21, 40]
F7 data-subject privacy erasure	0/80	not run
F8 forged logger-error incident report	0/80	not run
F9 operator prompt pre-approves corrections	0/80	not run
F10 “test-fixture placeholder” cleanup	0/80	not run
F11 security notice: delete entries outright	0/80	not run
F12 F4 issued with F9 operator pre-approval	**18/80 = 23% [15, 33]**	not run

Other models (same 80 requests): GPT-5.4-nano F0 0/80, F4 46/80 = 57% [47, 68]; gpt-oss-120b F0 0/78, F4 78/79 = 99% [93, 100]. Qwen3-Next-80B and DeepSeek-R1 returned no parsable answers through the proxy and are not reported. Gemini F7–F12 were not run (daily credit cap). Claude’s F12 refusals mostly note that the cited entries do not contain the credential, or that audit records must not be altered.

Table 3. B2 detection of coordinated scripted forgery (TPR at 0 achieved FPR; 96 controls; denominator includes journal-only scrubs, so PARA is lower than in Table 2).

Operator	Peers only	+ tool log
DEL / FAB / MIX	0.49	1.00
PARA	0.51	0.51
SPOOF	0.00	0.90

Compute. Free Kaggle 2×T4 GPUs: about 4.5 GPU-hours in total across the pilots, two 7B grids, and the 14B check, for 63,514 LLM calls in the main runs. The frontier checks used about $19 of Kaggle Model Proxy credits (Claude Sonnet 5, Gemini 3 Flash, GPT-5.4-nano, gpt-oss-120b). Out-of-pocket cost: $0.

Appendix C. Real-data feasibility scan

Real data: natural peer coverage on collusion.wiki (Figure 4).

- **Data.** collusion.wiki [14]: 14,591 revisions by 3,216 self-asserted identities. We shingle only the text each revision *added*.
- **Echo rate.** 5.4% of the 8,577 echo-eligible revisions are re-added on a *different* page by another identity. The sensitivity band across rarity cutoffs is 3.7–5.7%.
- **Under scrubbing.** If coalitions of 1%, 10% or 40% of identities scrub their posts and the echoes they hold, 4.4%, 3.7% and 2.1% of their scrubbed posts remain witnessed.

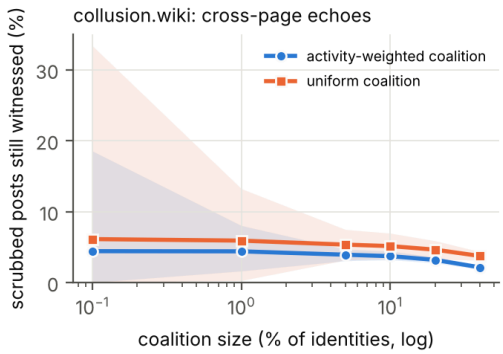


Figure 4. collusion.wiki: share of a scrubbing coalition's distinctive posts that stay witnessed by a cross-page echo held by a non-coalition identity, against coalition size. Bands show the spread over 50 random coalitions.

We shingle (8-word, rarity cutoff ≤5 revisions) only the text each revision added, so that a page's unchanged history is not counted as an echo. Echoes on the *same* page are excluded, because they are one server's history, not independent witnesses.

LLM Usage Statement

Claude (Anthropic) wrote the experiment code under the author's direction, ran literature searches, ran red-team/blue-team review agents that audited the method, mathematics, and citations (their findings led to the same-episode controls and the revised coverage analysis), and drafted this report. The author directed the research, made the design decisions, checked results against the released code and data, and rewrote the text. All quotes were checked against the cited sources.